

La conscience juste, les obstacles comme chemin vers la libération et les trois caractéristiques

Bhante Bodhidhamma · International Talks · 1:06:26

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This evening, I just want to cover some basic ground. For some of you, it's hopefully a timely reminder, and for others, maybe some new information. There are three things that must be clear for us in practising *vipassanā* meditation, or even in daily life. First, understanding what the Buddha means when he speaks of right mindfulness and how to use it. How do we manage the mental states that turn us away from right mindfulness and how do we use them? And finally, what are we really investigating and exploring?

The first question, what is right mindfulness, is exemplified by the story of the Buddha himself. Remember, he left his family following what we would recognise as an existential crisis. Somehow, when he was young, around the age of twenty, he became aware of the four divine messengers. He saw a very old person, a dead person, a very sick person, and also a monk sitting under a tree.

This story serves to illustrate that at some point in our lives, when we are around twenty years old, we begin to realise that life is not always rosy, that it's not always easy. There are also those who don't realise this until they are older, in their forties or fifties. And some poor people never get there until their deathbed. The fact that we are all here means that at some point in our lives, we have realised that there is illness, that there will be old age and death awaiting us, and that there may be an escape from the suffering this causes us.

Obviously, these things are completely natural. They are part of life. We age, we become ill, and then we die. As the comedian said, life is hard and then you die.

The Buddha began by exploring different forms of meditation that resulted in very wonderful states of mind. And all these practices he explored, which were mainly what we call concentration practices, absorption practices, he realised did not answer this existential question he had. Questions like: why are we born? Why must we die? What does it all mean? This is a big question. So this practice did not provide the answer.

I think I'm correct in saying that there is only one occasion in the scriptures where the Buddha speaks of an experience that happened to him when he was a child. This was an occasion when, as a young boy, he was watching his father participate in a ceremony that opened the ploughing season.

One must imagine that after having tried all sorts of different practices, especially mortifications, he was in a state of exhaustion. It would seem he was sitting by the roadside, probably wondering what he should do now, when a young woman came along with sweet rice she was going to offer at a shrine. Seeing him in this state, she offered this food to the Buddha instead.

And so, it seems that at that moment, the Buddha had this memory of when he was a child. And what he says in the story, in the texts, is that when he was a child, the Buddha was in the same state of concentration that he had practised later with his teachers. But there was clearly something that was different. And that was, of course, this quality of investigation that was present in his mind, this wondering about what his father was doing.

We call these the *vipassanā-jhāna*, or the vipassanā absorption states. In other words, in our practice, we can concentrate as much as someone who practises *jhāna*, but there is this quality of investigation. So in our way of practising, we can reach levels of concentration that are as high as those who practise the *jhānas*, but the difference is that our approach has this quality of investigation. This is the crucial difference. It really is the absolutely crucial difference.

If you imagine a child of maybe seven years old, although we also see this kind of wonder in children up to the age of ten, they have this kind of amazement on their faces. This can also happen to us as adults. So when a child, and sometimes we ourselves, when a child sees something they don't know, they stop dead and look at it intensely. And they have their mouth open, which makes them look a bit silly.

So the good parent immediately tells them, stop that, wake up. A meditator told me that her father would tell her to keep her mouth closed, otherwise a fly might get in. And when we see someone who has this expression that we ourselves make, with an open mouth, really looking, what is actually happening is that we have stopped thinking. And the fact that the jaw has relaxed, that the mouth is open, all this is really very intimately connected to thinking. When the mouth is open, it tells us that there is no thought. So it's empty of thinking, but that means there is no conceptual thinking. We are in direct contact with the information that is being processed, treating this information directly.

So when a child does this, they will keep their gaze for a moment, and then they will turn to someone and ask, "but what is this?" And once the parent has said "a spider," for example, then that's the label, the little word. And that's the beginning of having a concept of spiders. And so the next time the child sees a spider, they cry "Ah there, a spider, a spider!" And mum and dad say "Oh, very good, very good!" But the child has never looked properly at this species again, not the way they saw the first one. They have simply integrated it into their perception. But the child no longer looked at the spider in the same way. In fact, they didn't look at all. Not like the first time. All they did was put it in a box, labelling the spider.

And this is what we do all the time. So this is what we do, and each time we see something, whether we are aware of it or not, we have a label for this thing, and we give it one. As we said this morning, this is the reason for using this notation, this labelling, because it becomes very clear to us what is happening. And there is another reason for noting: it gives us a certain distance from the object. And we will return to this at the end of the teaching.

So this way of looking at things has two qualities: the intuitive awareness that receives the information, and the intuitive intelligence that grasps and understands what's going on. And so when the Buddha speaks of establishing this kind of consciousness, he always speaks of *sati sampajañña*, that is, mindfulness with intuitive intelligence.

There is a very good teacher in Thailand, Buddhādāsa, who used the word *satipañña* to refer to the inner Buddha. This gives us an idea of what it is, and our work is to constantly return to this pure intuitive awareness.

And what prevents us from getting there is what the Buddha calls the hindrances. There are five of them, and each one tells us what the problem is and how we should tackle it. The first, of course, concerns desire, what we want. So for example, if in our meditation we are surrounded by this fantasy, this dream of travelling to Machu Picchu or some exotic place, if we don't pay attention, then it's really going to overwhelm our meditation.

I have a friend who practised for three months at IMS, the centre in the United States started by Joseph Goldstein and Sharon Salzberg. And he told me that he had spent almost all three months planning a trip to South America. Of course, the irony is that he never went there. These fantasies can have a great hold on us.

The reason why, and this is true for all the hindrances, is that these mental states are like attitudes, they are like balloons. So we have an attitude of clinging to what we want. It's an internal attitude towards something that is desirable. It's not what we desire that creates this attitude, it's our relationship that is not right with desire that creates... It's not the object that creates the attitude, it's the attitude that is created around an object.

When I do this, for example, it's to illustrate the balloon. So when something manifests that attracts us, it's like everything in the balloon wants to escape through this little hole. And if your concentration is good, it's like you're compressing the balloon. So everything comes out even faster with a lot of force.

So as soon as we see the mind distracted by a fantasy, we really have to be there with it. So we use the word "planning, planning" and this allows us to see what the mind is doing and to have a reflection on what the mind is doing. And as soon as we recognise it, we know what we must do to prevent it from going further.

And it's quite possible that the desire is so strong that we can feel it in the body as an energy, an

excitement. And so at that moment, the word used might change to become "excitement, excitement." And we are using the word so that attention is really firmly planted, anchored in the feeling that is manifested.

In the discourse on the establishment of mindfulness, the Buddha uses this phrase of feeling feelings in feelings. Of feeling physical sensations in physical sensations. Of feeling mental states in mental states. And so it seems to me that he also had this problem of making sure that people really feel the sensations, the feelings.

So when you have noted "planning, planning" and you return and you can feel it, if this is not the case, you return to the mind, you continue to use these noting words to stay with what you are experiencing. And after having used these words "planning, planning," maybe you don't feel it, so you return, you don't feel anything, so you return to the breath and you continue to use these notes to really be with what you are experiencing.

And when you do this, when you are really there, you will perhaps notice that there is a little tendency, a little energy wanting to escape, wanting to return to the dream. And so we must be very aware of this, because just a nanosecond of inattention and we are gone elsewhere. We must remember that the mind is really lively and if it is inattentive for a second, it is just gone. Our work is really to stay planted with the experience as it unfolds.

All this is also true for the other hindrances. And when it comes to things we don't like, there are more or less two categories. The first category consists of mental states we like, in which we like to indulge, like perhaps anger. And there are others, like perhaps very deep sadness, that we don't like to feel. And also in this second category, there would be things like jealousy, which we find very, very difficult to really let go of.

And so with anger, for example, we often treat it much the same way as things we desire. And when it comes to things that are difficult for us to feel - depression, deep sadness - then we must be aware of our tendency to push them away, to reject them. And so we must be aware of our desire not to experience them, and then develop an attitude of kindness.

So for example, take loneliness. Nobody likes to feel lonely. We prefer to watch television, cook, call a friend. Everything to avoid feeling alone and isolated. Actually, we must open ourselves to this feeling and really listen to what it is telling us. So: nobody loves you, nobody could love you, you will always be alone and that's how it is. It's the order of things.

And so instead, we open ourselves to this kind of experience. We have an attitude of kindness towards this feeling. Now, if we can stay until the end of this emotional energy, to stay until the end, we can really experience transformation. And so if we manage to really be present with this feeling until its end, then we can perhaps have the experience of its transformation.

Nothing is lost in this process. Everything is transformed. We were selfish, we find ourselves becoming

generous. We were full of hatred and anger, we find ourselves becoming tolerant, loving. We were cruel and malevolent, we find ourselves becoming more compassionate, more kind. This is not something we have to do, it's something that happens quite naturally. The heart heals in awareness.

And this is comparable to a wound that heals. So when we cut ourselves with a knife, the body heals itself. Our role is to keep the wound clean. Antiseptic. We prevent the heart from going into sepsis, into inflammation, by being aware. So we prevent the body from becoming infected, inflamed, by being aware.

So now, the third thing is torpor and lethargy, but we'll come back to that. The fourth thing is restlessness and all these emotions we have when we do something harmful. So the third hindrance is torpor and drowsiness, but we'll come back to it. And then the fourth is restlessness and all the things that make us do things that are unwholesome. So it's a bit of a catch-all category, so if your state doesn't correspond to the other three hindrances, then restlessness covers a bit all these states. When we are agitated in this way, it's very difficult to stay...

Donc, on est tranquille avec le corps agité et l'esprit qui veut aller dans tous les sens. Quand on a vraiment cette agitation du corps, essayez de vous détendre autour du corps. Quand vous ressentez cette agitation, cette tension, quoi que vous puissiez relâcher, détendre, faites-le. Et c'est quelquefois utile de simplement faire un balayage de la tête jusqu'aux pieds, en vraiment explorant les endroits où vous ressentez vraiment cette agitation. Mais si vous pouvez, comme toutes ces choses, si vous pouvez mettre votre attention dans cette restlessness, vous donnez au cœur une chance de relâcher cette énergie. Mais si vous y arrivez, vous restez vraiment planté, présent avec cette agitation là où elle se manifeste, vous êtes en train de donner au cœur la possibilité de se guérir de cette agitation.

Il y a un autre aspect de cet empêchement qui a à voir avec la culpabilité et la honte. Ce sont des états que nous trouvons très difficiles à assumer. La culpabilité arise parce que nous avons fait quelque chose de mal, alors nous devons essayer de faire ce que nous pouvons pour mettre ça en place. C'est simple. Évidemment, si nous nous sentons coupables parce que nous avons fait quelque chose qui a fait du mal, alors évidemment, il faut essayer de réparer si possible. Et la honte, c'est le sentiment de perdre l'estime de soi. Si vous pouvez faire quelque chose qui vous aide à rééquilibrer, qui vous fait reprendre un peu de votre estime de soi, c'est aussi très utile.

Il faut aussi se rappeler que pour la plupart, nos sentiments de culpabilité et de honte sont exagérés. C'est un peu comme avec le désir. Les sentiments de culpabilité sont comme des ballons pour toutes les choses terribles que nous avons faites dans notre vie et nous nous sentons coupables. Même chose pour toutes les choses honteuses que nous avons fait dans notre vie. Donc, parfois, la culpabilité et la honte que nous ressentons par rapport à quelque chose n'est vraiment pas proportionnelle. Et donc c'est la même chose, il faut laisser ces choses se manifester et vous êtes en train de vider le cœur de ces états mentaux malsains.

Et de même avec le doute. Et ici, on parle du doute sceptique. Donc, c'est le doute qui nous empêche d'agir. C'est une force qui peut être assez destructrice dans nos vies. Et ça provient d'une peur de faillite, d'une

faillite de confiance. Tu appliques pour un travail, et tout ce doute s'élève : « Peux-je le faire ? Suis-je assez bon ? » Et pendant que tu es perdue dans ton doute, le travail va à quelqu'un d'autre. C'est la même chose avec les relations. Je ne suis pas assez bon, peut-être qu'ils ne m'aiment pas. Et avant que tu te rendes compte, ils sont allés et ont trouvé quelqu'un d'autre.

Dans notre méditation, normalement, maintenant qu'on se situe et qu'on pratique, nos doutes ne sont pas tant dans le Bouddha, ou dans l'enseignement, ou dans la pratique. C'est généralement en nous-mêmes. Je ne suis pas assez bon, je n'arrive pas à quelque chose. Je ne vois pas de progrès. Et donc, comme nous sommes en train de pratiquer, notre doute n'est pas tellement dirigé vers le Bouddha et les enseignements, mais plutôt vers nous-mêmes. On se dit : « Je ne me fais pas assez bien, je ne suis pas assez douée, assez habile », et nous dirigeons ces choses vers nous-mêmes. C'est la même chose, donc il faut vraiment rester avec ce sentiment d'échec, des sentiments de doute, ces sentiments de ne pas être à la hauteur, et puis de voir le changement.

Pour retourner à la torpeur et la somnolence, ce sont des énergies très lourdes qui nous terrassent et qui nous font descendre dans le corps vers le néant. Et bien sûr, il n'y a pas de souffrance dans le néant, mais il n'y a pas d'éveil non plus. Donc, on fait de son mieux pour rester réveillé. Et de nouveau, tout ce que l'on fait, c'est qu'on permet au cœur de relâcher cette énergie malsaine. Il faut vraiment le sentir. Vous pouvez regarder les différents endroits dans le corps où vous ressentez cette fatigue, cette somnolence. Cela vous permet de rester réveillé. Chaque fois qu'il y a cette attention, il y a aussi une intention, et cette intention donne un peu de pouvoir. Et même si c'est une torpeur dans la tête, alors simplement, bougez votre attention dans la tête. Regardez différentes choses.

Et donc, ce qui se passe, c'est que non seulement cette énergie malsaine, en l'observant, lui permettait de se relâcher, mais aussi ça nous permet de se transformer en énergie pure. Et donc, comme nous avons expliqué les cinq empêchements, nous pouvons voir que c'est notre relation avec ces états qui est le problème.

Donc, ce que nous sommes en train de regarder, de contempler, c'est le désir, le vouloir, le ne pas vouloir, le désir et l'aversion. Voilà. Et ça, c'est un niveau de la libération. Et donc, une des voies vers la libération est de comprendre le processus du mauvais désir. Le deuxième est de voir l'impermanence. Et dans notre pratique, c'est assez facile à voir. Il n'y a aucune respiration qui se répète, aucune pensée. Rien ne se répète. Nous sommes très rapides à voir quelque chose de nouveau, mais nous n'aimons pas voir la fin des choses.

Avant la fin de quelque chose, nous sommes déjà en train de penser à la prochaine chose, la prochaine chose, le prochain film à regarder, la prochaine personne à qui parler, la prochaine chose à voir. Nous sommes toujours un peu au-devant de nous-mêmes. La raison pour laquelle nous faisons ça, c'est que toutes les fins sont une mort. Une petite mort, mais une mort. Nous fuyons la fin des choses, la fin d'un pas, la fin d'une respiration. Toujours la fin.

Et c'est ainsi que nous subissons ce sens de soi, parce que le soi veut toujours savoir ce qui viendra. Il n'aime pas ne pas savoir ce qui viendra. Et c'est une façon aussi d'aller contre le sens du soi, parce que le sens du soi veut toujours savoir ce qui vient, ce qui va venir, ce qui va se passer.

Et pour comprendre le non-soi, la façon la plus facile, c'est de regarder ce que l'on peut contrôler et ce qu'on ne peut pas contrôler. D'une façon très simple, quand nous parlons du corps, nous disons « j'ai un mal de tête », ou « je suis malade ». Et ça, c'est une possession et une identification avec cet organisme. Et c'est alors qu'on peut commencer à reconnaître que nous n'avons qu'un contrôle minimal. Par exemple, nous ne savons pas ce que notre foie est en train de faire juste maintenant.

Donc, très rapidement, ce sont les trois avenues d'investigation qui conduisent à la libération. Le premier, c'est ce désir faux. Le deuxième, c'est l'impermanence. Et le troisième, c'est le non-soi.

Et le noter, vous voyez, nous aide à distancer de ce que nous expérimentons. Donc, par exemple, si vous avez une douleur dans le dos, vous pouvez dire « Il y a une douleur ». C'est autre, c'est quelque chose que vous expérimentez, qui n'est pas la même chose que ce qui expérimente. Noter nous permet de nous distancer de notre expérience. Par exemple, si nous avons mal au genou, alors la douleur, elle est là, elle est là-bas. Et donc on sent cette distance entre ce qui est expérimenté et ce qui est en train d'expérimenter.

Donc ce soir, nous avons parlé de l'attention juste, le visage de l'enfant, comment gérer ces hindrances un peu, comment s'approcher, comment gérer les empêchements pour faire en sorte que les empêchements eux-mêmes deviennent un chemin vers la libération. Et de voir que tout ce dont nous avons l'expérience est un objet que nous ne contrôlons pas directement.

Que je souhaite que ce que j'ai dit vous ait aidé, que je ne vous ai pas causé de la confusion et que vous serez libérés de toute votre souffrance, tôt plutôt que tard.

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